Module09 – Interaction Design Critique and Iteration

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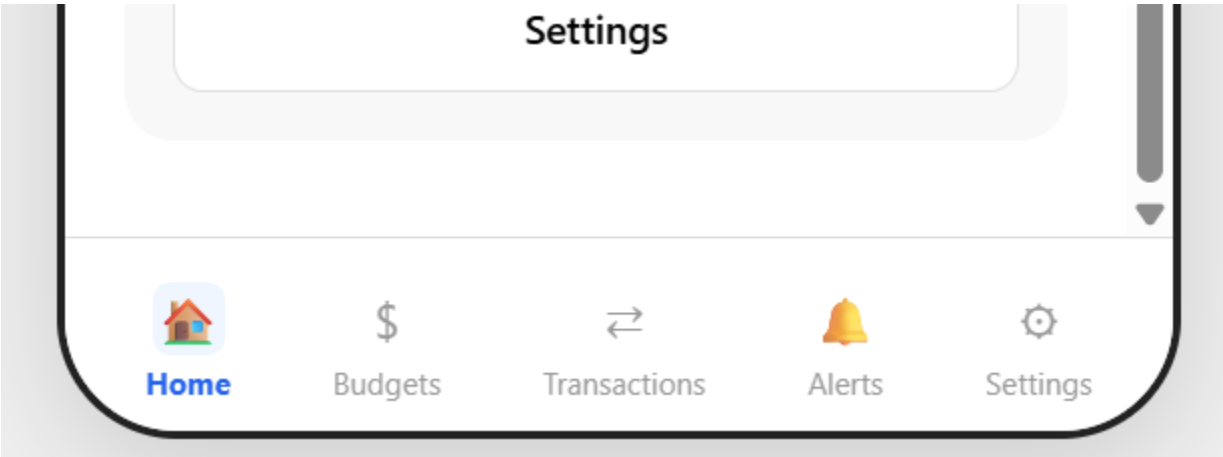
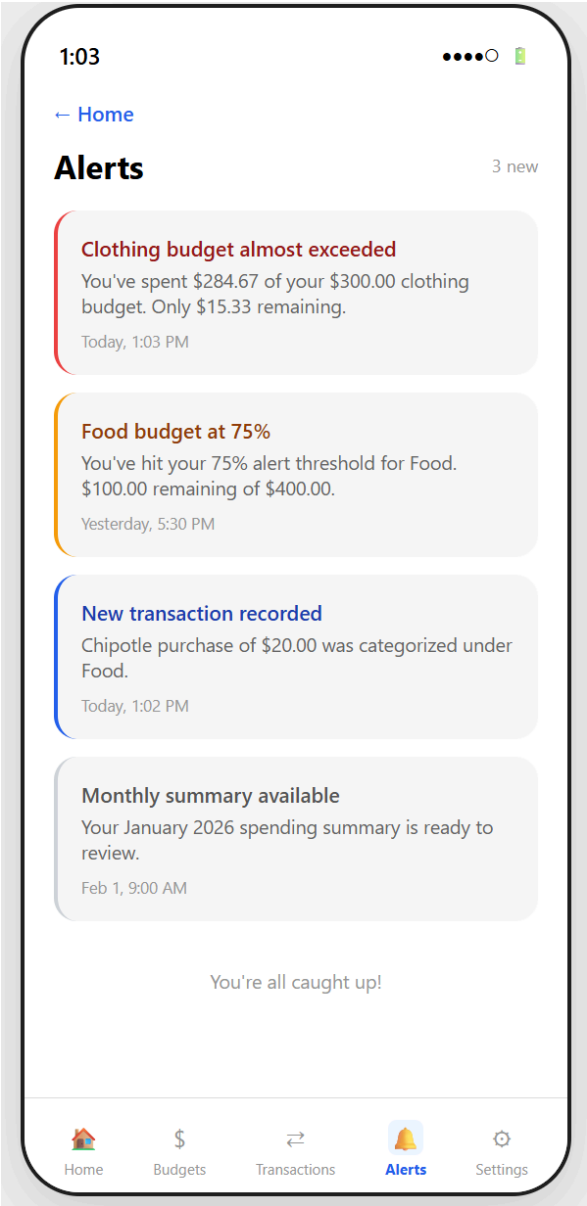
Previous URL (“after” for module 9):
https://laws-smith-luna.github.io/User-Interface-Design/after-m9/

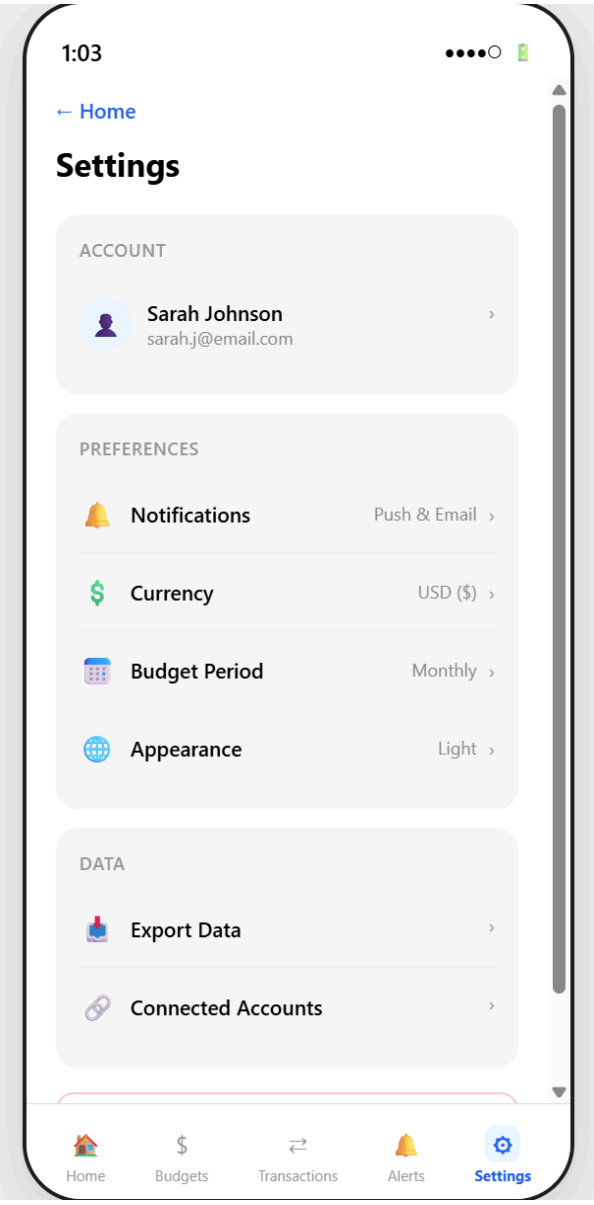
After URL:

Weakness 1: Alerts and Settings navigation tabs are non-functional dead ends



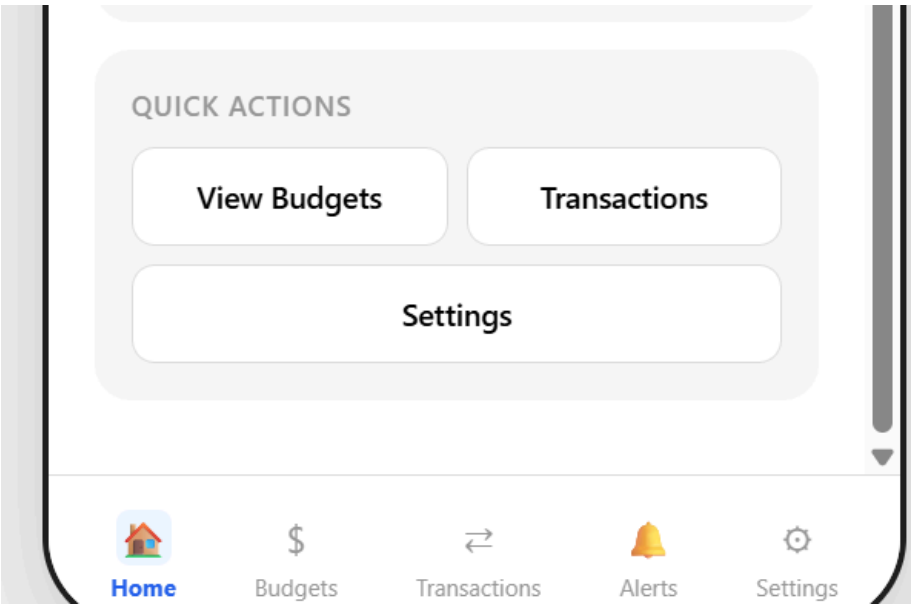
The bottom navigation bar includes five tabs (Home, Budgets, Transactions, Alerts, Settings), but tapping Alerts or Settings produces no response. There is no screen change, no loading state, no feedback of any kind. Norman describes this gap as the "gulf of evaluation" in *The Design of Everyday Things*, where the user cannot tell whether their action had any effect. When a button looks tappable but does nothing, users are left wondering whether the app is broken or whether they missed the tap target.



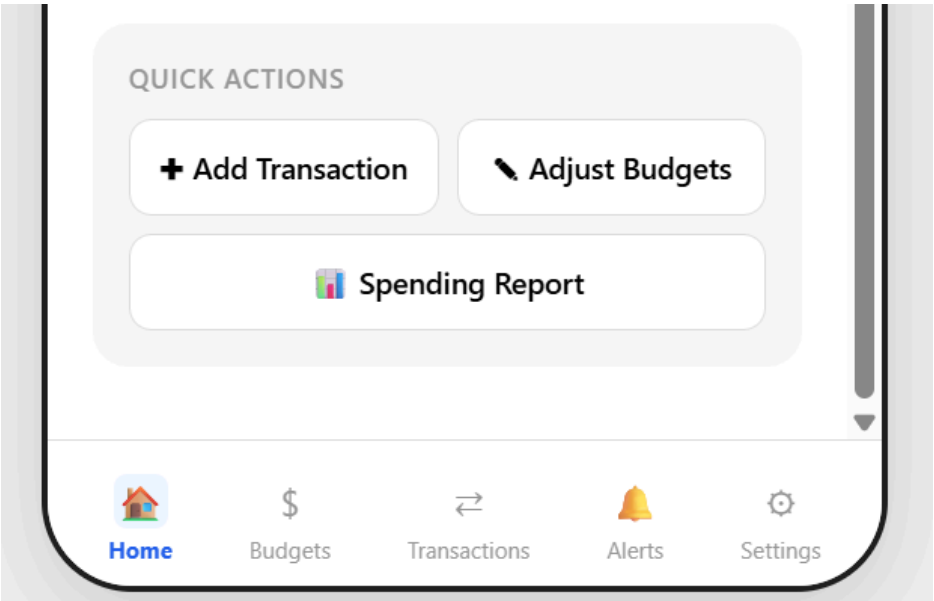


The Alerts and Settings tabs now navigate to dedicated screens. The Alerts screen displays a chronological list of budget notifications with timestamps, and the Settings screen provides access to profile and notification preferences. Users now receive immediate visual feedback when tapping any navigation item.

Weakness 2: Dashboard Quick Actions duplicates the bottom navigation bar



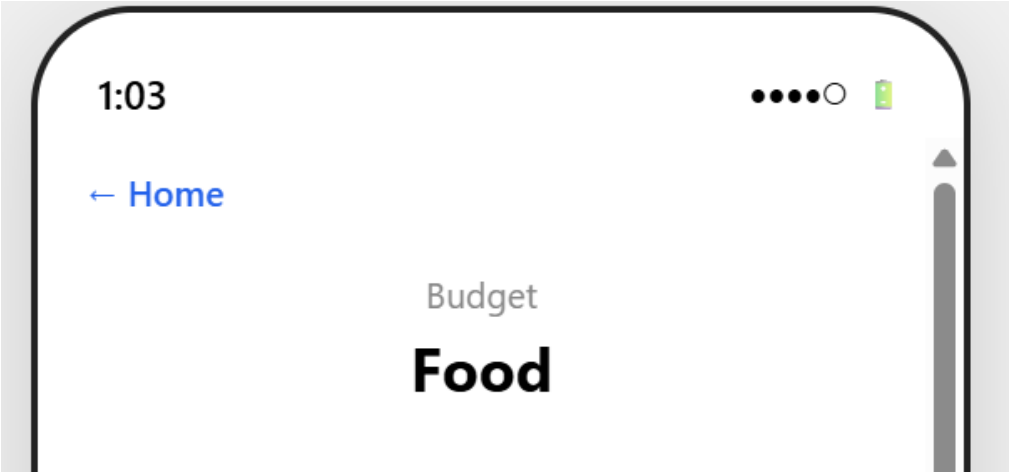
The Dashboard's Quick Actions card contains three buttons: "View Budgets," "Transactions," and "Settings." All three are already accessible from the bottom navigation bar visible on every screen. In chapter 7 of *Don't Make Me Think*, Krug states that you should try to promote everything on the homepage. Applying Krug's advice to the Dashboard, the Quick Actions section should surface context-specific shortcuts rather than repeat navigation the user already has. The duplication wastes screen space and creates an unnecessary decision point between two identical paths to the same destination.



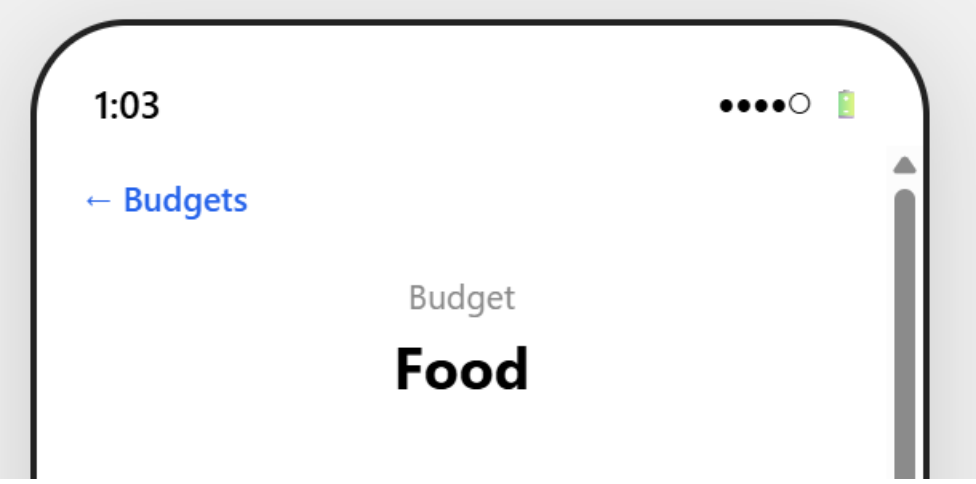
The Quick Actions card now offers contextual shortcuts that complement the bottom navigation: "Add Transaction," "Adjust Budgets," and "View Spending Report." These are

actions a user returning to their dashboard would actually want to do quickly, rather than generic navigation available one tap away on the bottom bar.

Weakness 3: Back button on budget detail screens is mislabeled

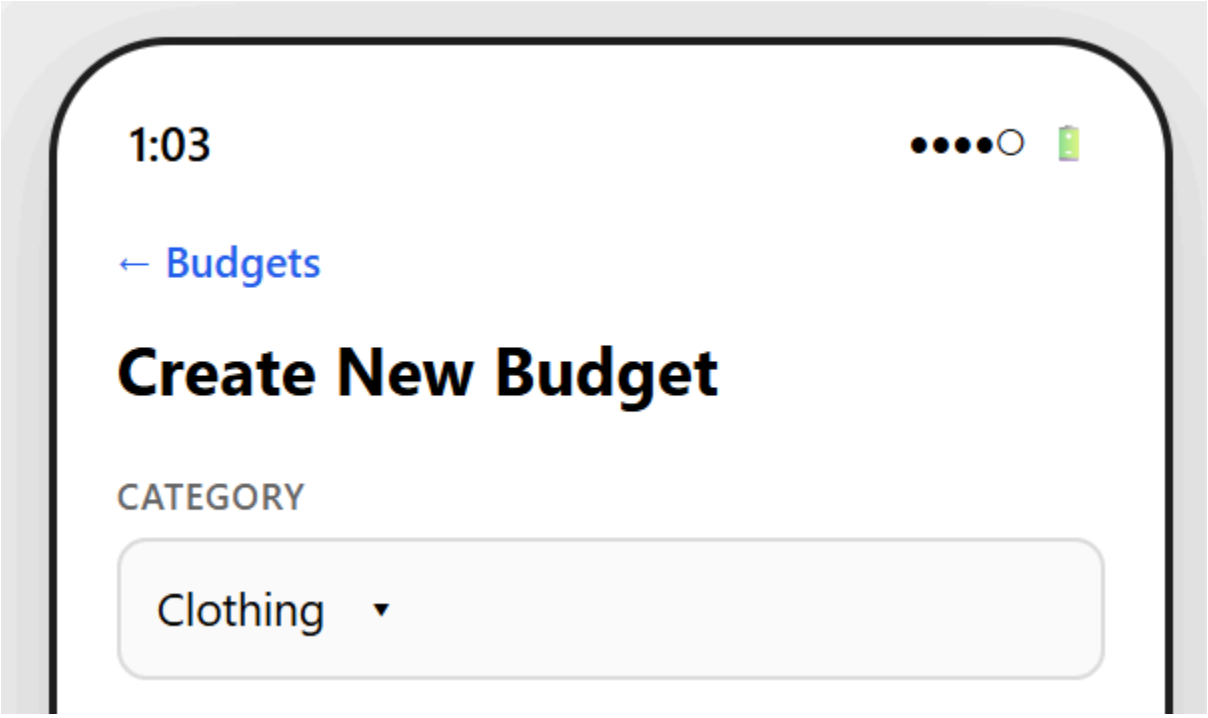


The Clothing Budget, Food Budget, and Updated Food Budget detail screens all display a back button labeled "← Home" that navigates to the Dashboard. However, a user viewing a budget detail screen would expect to return to the Budgets list, not the Dashboard. This violates Consistency and Standards. Users expect the back button to return them to the previous logical level in the navigation hierarchy, which is the Budgets list. Labeling it "Home" forces extra navigation steps to get back to the budget list.

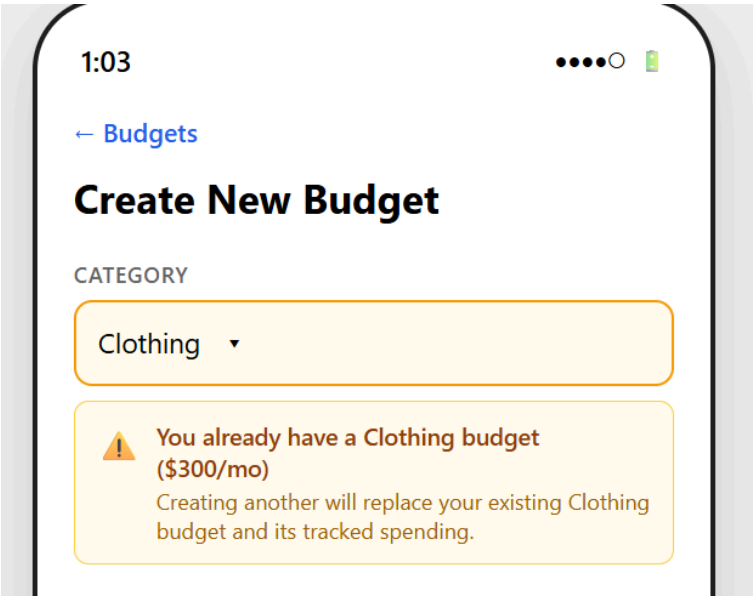


The back button on all budget detail screens now reads "← Budgets" and navigates to the Budgets list. This matches the user's mental model of the hierarchy and lets users move between the list and detail views without being routed through the Dashboard.

Weakness 4: Category dropdown does not prevent creating duplicate budgets

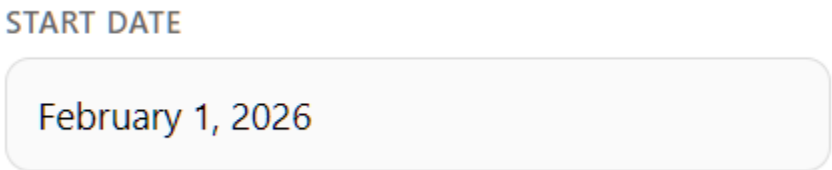


The Create New Budget form lets users select any category from the dropdown, including categories that already have an active budget. If a user selects "Clothing" (which already has a $300/month budget), the form proceeds without any warning. In chapter 5 of *The Design of Everyday Things*, Norman states that there should be sensibility checks so that small errors like this do not snowball into bigger issues down the line. The user does not intend to create a conflicting budget, but the interface offers no guardrail to catch this slip before it becomes a committed error.



The category dropdown now displays a warning banner when the user selects a category with an existing budget (e.g., "You already have a Clothing budget at $300/mo. Creating another will replace it."). This gives the user the information they need to decide whether to proceed or pick a different category, preventing accidental duplicates while still allowing intentional replacement.

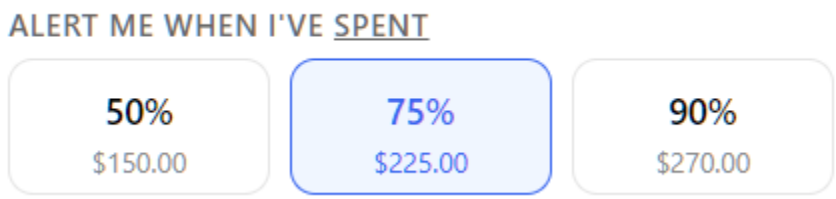
Weakness 5: No signifier that users can change date when creating a budget



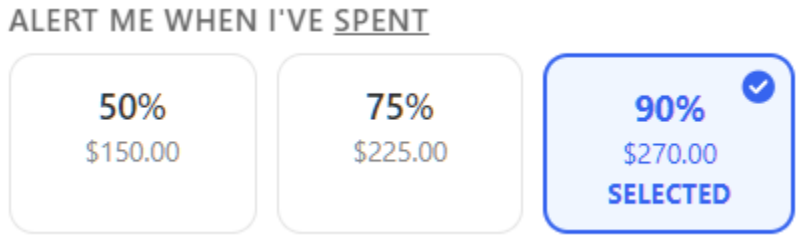
The Create New Budget screen pre fills in the start date of any new budgets you make with the first day of the month. However, there is no indicator that users can edit this date. In chapter 5 of *Design of Everyday Things,* Norman states there should be affordance signifiers that communicate to users what they are able to do. There are no such signifiers here and users may not know that the start date is editable.

The start date box now has a label indicating that the start date can be changed by tapping on the box. There is also a calendar icon that generally signifies a date is editable. These changes clearly convey to users the start date is editable.

Weakness 6: Alert selection is not accessible

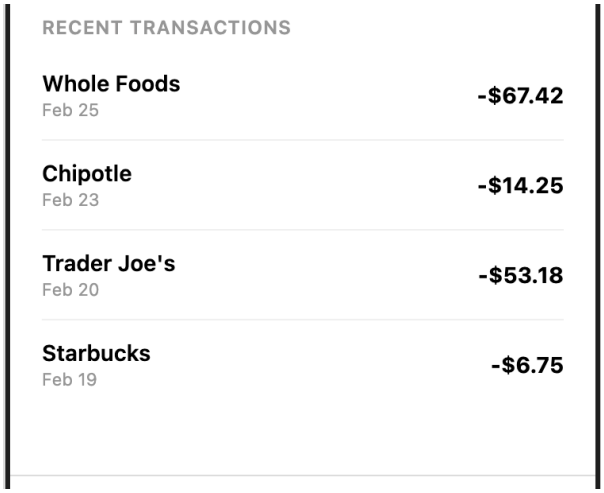


The Create New Budget screen allows users to select when the app warns you that your budget is running low. However, the only indicator of what option you have selected is only a color change. In Chapter 11 of *Don't Make Me Think,* Krug emphasizes accessibility when designing interfaces. This design may not be accessible for users that have color differentiating colors.

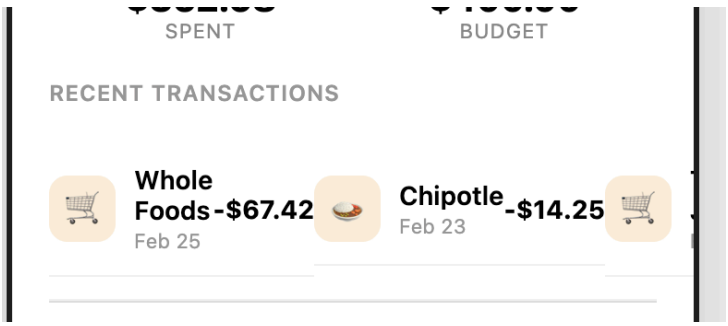


The Alert Me When I've Spent selector now includes a blue checkmark in the top right corner of whatever choice is selected. Users that have difficulty differentiating between colors now have another signifier to show them what option they have selected. This lets more people be able to use the app effectively.

Weakness 7: Transaction list relies solely on text for category identification



The previous design violates Nielsen's Usability Heuristic: Recognition rather than Recall. By presenting transactions as a text-only list, the interface forces users to read every merchant name and manually "recall" which budget category that store belongs to (e.g., remembering that "Chipotle" is "Food"). This increases the user's cognitive load. According to site design principles regarding visual scanning, users should be able to identify patterns at a glance. Without visual signifiers like icons or category labels, the interface fails to provide the "information scent" necessary for a user to quickly assess their spending habits without intensive reading.



In the updated version, I added category-specific icons to the left of every transaction name. This change addresses the weakness by allowing users to use recognition (seeing the "Food" icon) rather than recall (remembering what Chipotle is). This follows the principle of providing clear visual cues to support rapid scanning, significantly reducing the time and mental effort required for a user to review their transaction history.